

WESTWARD DRIFT
US president Joe Biden; Ukrainian counterpart Volodymyr Zelensky

including a regime change that would make it a vassal state of Russia as it was before the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991. He even threatened to go nuclear if NATO interfered in his war, ominously warning "of consequences you have never faced in your history". There is every danger that a miscalculation on either side could push the world towards a catastrophic World War III, which former US defence secretary William Cohen says would result in "not just the end of history but of civilisation itself".

WHY PUTIN WENT TO WAR

As the fighting raged in Ukraine, round one of the information war went to the West, with Ukrainian president Volodymyr Zelensky, a comedian-turned-politician, hailed for his resilience and bravery in not abandoning

PUTIN WANTED A US ASSURANCE THAT UKRAINE WOULD NOT BE ALLOWED IN NATO. BIDEN THOUGHT HIS DEMANDS WOULDN'T STOP AT THAT

ship. Putin, on the other hand, was accused of suffering delusions of grandeur, with some even comparing him to a demented King Lear. But is there a method to Putin's seeming madness? There seems to be one. For one, the former KGB spy and judoka-turned-politician has now ruled Russia with an iron fist for over 21 years. When he took over in 2000, Russia was disunited, dejected and reduced to third-world country status. Putin rapidly consolidated control in his hands by reining in the oligarchs who had thrived in the Wild West kind of capitalism that took hold after the collapse of the Soviet Union. Leveraging the country's oil resources (Russia is now one of the world's largest suppliers of oil and gas), Putin rebuilt the economy, modernised the country's formidable military and also brought unity and order to Russia's 85 Oblasts (provinces).

He then positioned himself as a new Tsar, terming the 1991 dissolution of the Soviet Union as "the greatest geopolitical disaster of the 20th century". He lashed out at NATO for incorporating erstwhile Soviet satellites and republics as members (14 since 1991), contrary to US assurances that it would not intrude into the Russian sphere of influence. In 2008, when Georgia pushed for NATO membership, Putin launched a military operation to establish two of its breakaway regions—South Ossetia and Abkhazia—as independent republics. Ukraine, too, had applied for NATO membership the same year. In 2014, when pro-Russian president Viktor Yanukovych was ousted from power, Putin executed a bloodless annexation of Crimea, a peninsula on the Black Sea the Soviet Union had transferred to Ukraine in 1954.

While the West imposed fresh sanctions on Russia and its economy took a hit, Putin's own popularity soared on the back of the Crimean annexation. Emboldened, he orchestrated a Russian-backed insurgency in two other regions of Ukraine—Donetsk and Luhansk in the east—bordering Russia with the aim of creating a land corridor to Crimea. Ukraine, headed then by a new pro-West president, Petro Poroshenko, signed a ceasefire protocol with Russia and the separatists in Minsk in September 2014, but with no side keeping to its terms, that broke down. At this stage, France and Germany stepped in to broker a deal called Minsk 2 between Russia and Ukraine in February 2015: the conditions this time explicitly guaranteed that these two regions were to have greater autonomy, while ensuring that Ukraine would have control of its national borders here. However, hostilities between pro-Russian and nationalist forces in the region continued to escalate. And when Zelensky was elected in April 2019 with a landslide majority, he pushed hard for membership to the European Community (EC) and NATO. Meanwhile, he took British help to set up a naval base in Odessa, and the US supplied sophisticated arms worth over $2 billion to bolster the Ukrainian armed forces.

For Putin, Zelensky had crossed the invisible red line. "If Ukraine joined NATO, it would be like a permanent dagger pointed at Russia's throat. Imagine India's reaction if Nepal entered into a military alliance with China, including having missiles directed at us? Would we sit back and watch?" asks Bala Venkatesh Varma, a former Indian ambassador to Russia. Putin then threatened decisive military action by amassing Russian troops on the Ukrainian border unless the US gave a firm commitment that it would not admit Ukraine into NATO and end its expansion in the region. The Russian strongman also upped the ante by demanding a rollback of the previous admission of erstwhile Soviet Republics into NATO, removal of US nuclear weapons stationed in Europe and a formal recognition of Russia's security interests in the region, mainly Belarus, Ukraine and Georgia.